

# Word family: \*\*while / awhile\*\*

\*\*Base word:\*\* while

\*\*Related form:\*\* awhile

\*\*Useful expressions / extensions:\*\* while + clause, a while, for a while, once in a while, all the while, meanwhile, worthwhile

\*\*Part of speech:\*\* conjunction ( 連接詞 ) / noun ( 名詞 ) / adverb-like time expression ( 時間副詞用法 )

Your sentence:

> “I want to learn from her \*\*while\*\* I can.”

## Meaning in this passage

Here, \*\*while\*\* means:

> \*\*during the period of time when something is still possible\*\*

The speaker knows that the grandmother is getting older, so there is only a limited period during which the speaker can still spend time with her and learn from her directly.

\*\*繁體中文： \*\* 趁某個情況仍然存在 / 某件事仍然可以做到的時候；在……仍然可行的期間\*\*

\*\*中文翻譯： \*\*

> “I want to learn from her while I can.”

「我想\*\*趁現在還可以的時候\*\*多向她學習。」

Here:

\*\*while I can = 趁我現在仍然有機會 / 仍然做得到的時候\*\*

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# 1. \*\*while = during the time that ( 在……期間 ) — 當……的時候；在……期間\*\*

This is the core sense underlying your sentence.

### Practice 1 — Original

> “I want to learn from her \*\*while I can\*\*.”

「我想\*\*趁現在還可以的時候\*\*向她學習。」

### ### Practice 2

> “She listened to music **while she cooked**.”

「她**煮飯時**聽音樂。」

### ### Practice 3

> “I read the newspaper **while I was waiting**.”

「我**等待期間**看報紙。」

**while + clause** = 在某件事情持續進行的同一段時間內，另一件事情也發生

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# 2. **while** = as long as the opportunity/situation lasts ( 趁.....仍然可以 ) — 趁.....的時候

This is your exact contextual branch.

### ### Practice 4

> “Enjoy the sunshine **while it lasts**.”

「**趁陽光還在的時候**好好享受吧。」

### ### Practice 5

> “Spend time with your family **while you can**.”

「**趁現在還有機會**，多陪伴家人。」

**while + present situation** = 趁某種情況仍然存在或某件事仍然可能做到的期間

This often carries a sense that the opportunity may not last forever.

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# 3. **while** = two actions happening at the same time ( 同時 ) — 當.....時；一邊.....一邊.....

### ### Practice 6

> “She smiled **while she spoke**.”

「她**一邊說話，一邊微笑**。」

### ### Practice 7

> “He worked **while** the children slept.”

「孩子睡覺時，他繼續工作。」

**while** = 連接兩件在同一段時間內同時發生的事情

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# 4. **while** = during a longer background action ( 背景時間 ) — 在.....期間

Often one action is longer and the other happens within it.

### ### Practice 8

> “Someone called **while** I was having dinner.”

「我**吃晚飯期間**有人打電話來。」

### ### Practice 9

> “The lights went out **while** we were watching TV.”

「我們**看電視時**突然停電了。」

**while** = 以一段持續中的動作 / 情況作背景，表示另一件事在其間發生

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# 5. **while** = whereas / in contrast ( 而；然而 ) — 而；相比之下

A major separate grammatical meaning.

### ### Practice 10

> “My sister loves cities, **while** I prefer the countryside.”

「我姐姐喜歡城市，**而**我比較喜歡鄉郊。」

### ### Practice 11

> “Some people work best in the morning, **while** others prefer the evening.”

「有些人在早上工作效率最好，**而**另一些人則喜歡晚上。」

**\*\*while = 把兩個人、事物或情況放在一起作對比；而 / 相比之下\*\***

Here **\*\*while\*\*** does not primarily express time.

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# 6. **\*\*while = although / despite the fact that ( 雖然 ) — 雖然；儘管\*\***

A more formal concessive use.

### Practice 12

> **“\*\*While\*\* I understand your point, I disagree.”**

「**\*\*雖然\*\***我明白你的觀點，但我不同意。」

### Practice 13

> **“\*\*While\*\* the plan is expensive, it may still be worthwhile.”**

「**\*\*雖然\*\***這個計劃昂貴，但它仍可能值得做。」

**\*\*while = 承認某個事實成立，同時引出另一個不同或相反的觀點\*\***

This is especially common in formal and academic writing.

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# 7. **\*\*a while = a period of time ( 一段時間 ) — 一會兒；一段時間\*\***

Now **\*\*while\*\*** functions as a noun.

### Practice 14

> **“Stay for **\*\*a while\*\***.”**

「留下來**\*\*一會兒\*\***吧。」

### Practice 15

> **“I haven’t seen her for **\*\*a while\*\***.”**

「我有**\*\*一段時間\*\***沒有見她了。」

**\*\*a while = 一段不精確、通常不太長的時間\*\***

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# 8. \*\*for a while ( 有一陣子 ) — 一會兒 ; 一段時間\*\*

### Practice 16

> “We talked \*\*for a while\*\*.”

「我們聊了\*\*一會兒\*\*。」

### Practice 17

> “She rested \*\*for a while\*\* before leaving.”

「她離開前休息了\*\*一陣子\*\*。」

\*\*for a while = 持續一段不精確的時間\*\*

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# 9. \*\*after a while ( 過了一會兒 ) — 過了一陣子\*\*

### Practice 18

> “\*\*After a while\*\*, she felt better.”

「\*\*過了一會兒\*\*，她感覺好多了。」

### Practice 19

> “The noise stopped \*\*after a while\*\*.”

「\*\*過了一陣子\*\*，噪音停了。」

\*\*after a while = 經過一段時間之後\*\*

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# 10. \*\*in a while ( 過一會兒 ) — 過一會 ; 稍後\*\*

### Practice 20

> “I’ll call you \*\*in a while\*\*.”

「我\*\*過一會兒\*\*打給你。」

### ### Practice 21

> “Dinner will be ready **\*\*in a while\*\***.”

「晚餐**\*\*過一會兒\*\***就準備好了。」

**\*\*in a while** = 從現在起過一段時間之後**\*\***

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# 11. **\*\*once in a while** ( 偶爾 ) — 偶爾 ; 間中**\*\***

A very common idiom.

### ### Practice 22

> “We eat out **\*\*once in a while\*\***.”

「我們**\*\*偶爾\*\***會外出吃飯。」

### ### Practice 23

> “She still visits her old neighbourhood **\*\*once in a while\*\***.”

「她仍然**\*\*間中\*\***會回舊社區看看。」

**\*\*once in a while** = 不經常 , 只偶爾發生**\*\***

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# 12. **\*\*all the while** ( 一直 ; 整段時間 ) — 一直 ; 在整段期間**\*\***

### ### Practice 24

> “He smiled, but **\*\*all the while\*\*** he was worried.”

「他面帶笑容 , 但其實**\*\*一直\*\***都很擔心。」

### ### Practice 25

> “She said nothing, **\*\*all the while\*\*** listening carefully.”

「她沒有說話 , 卻**\*\*一直\*\***專心聽著。」

**\*\*all the while** = 在整段時間內一直如此**\*\***

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# 13. \*\*a little while ( 短短一會兒 ) — 一小會 ; 一陣子\*\*

### Practice 26

> “Wait \*\*a little while\*\*.”

「等\*\*一小會兒\*\*。」

### Practice 27

> “She sat quietly for \*\*a little while\*\*.”

「她安靜地坐了\*\*一會兒\*\*。」

\*\*a little while = 一段較短、不精確的時間\*\*

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# 14. \*\*quite a while ( 相當長一段時間 ) — 好一段時間\*\*

### Practice 28

> “I haven’t spoken to him for \*\*quite a while\*\*.”

「我已經\*\*好一段時間\*\*沒有跟他說話了。」

### Practice 29

> “It took \*\*quite a while\*\* to finish.”

「花了\*\*相當長一段時間\*\*才完成。」

\*\*quite a while = 一段相當長、比預期更久的時間\*\*

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# 15. \*\*worth your while ( 值得花時間 / 精力 ) — 值得\*\*

A useful fixed expression.

### Practice 30

> “It would be \*\*worth your while\*\* to read the report.”

「你花時間讀這份報告是\*\*值得的\*\*。」

#### ### Practice 31

> “The course is definitely \*\*worth your while\*\*.”

「這個課程絕對\*\*值得你花時間參加\*\*。」

**\*\*worth someone's while = 值得某人付出時間、精力或努力\*\***

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# 16. **\*\*worthwhile = worth the time/effort ( 值得的 ) — 值得做的 ; 有價值的\*\***

A lexicalized extension historically connected to the same time idea.

#### ### Practice 32

> “The trip was difficult but **\*\*worthwhile\*\***.”

「這趟旅程雖然辛苦，但很**\*\*值得\*\***。」

#### ### Practice 33

> “Volunteering can be a very **\*\*worthwhile\*\*** experience.”

「做義工可以是一段很**\*\*有價值的經歷\*\***。」

**\*\*worthwhile = 值得投入時間、努力或資源，因為結果有價值\*\***

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# 17. **\*\*awhile = for a short time ( 一會兒 ) — 一會兒\*\***

A related adverb that learners often confuse with **\*\*a while\*\***.

#### ### Practice 34

> “Stay **\*\*awhile\*\***.”

「留下來**\*\*一會兒\*\***。」

#### ### Practice 35

> “She rested **\*\*awhile\*\*** before continuing.”

「她休息了\*\*一會兒\*\*才繼續。」

**\*\*awhile = for a short period of time ; 一會兒\*\***

It is less common than **\*\*for a while\*\*** in everyday English.

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# 18. **\*\*meanwhile = during the same time / in contrast ( 與此同時 ) — 同時 ; 另一方面\*\***

A useful lexical extension built from **\*\*while\*\***.

### ### Practice 36

> “She prepared the food. **\*\*Meanwhile\*\***, I made the tea.”

「她準備食物。**\*\*與此同時\*\***，我泡茶。」

### ### Practice 37

> “One department is growing; **\*\*meanwhile\*\***, another is shrinking.”

「一個部門正在增長；**\*\*另一方面\*\***，另一個則在縮減。」

**\*\*meanwhile = 在同一段時間內；亦可用來轉到另一個同時存在的情況\*\***

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**## Important distinction: \*\*while vs when\*\***

This is one of the most important contrasts.

**### \*\*while\*\***

often emphasizes:

> a period of time / duration

> “I listened while she was speaking.”

**### \*\*when\*\***

often emphasizes:

> a time point or event

> “I called when I arrived.”

So **while** is especially natural when the background action continues for some time.

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**## Important distinction: while vs during**

**### while + clause**

> “while I was studying”

**### during + noun phrase**

> “during the lesson”

Therefore:

> **while the lesson** ❌

> **during I was studying** ❌

Correct:

> **while I was studying**

> **during the lesson**

This is a major grammar distinction.

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**## Important distinction: while vs whereas**

When expressing contrast:

**### while**

> “She likes tea, while I prefer coffee.”

**### whereas**

> “She likes tea, whereas I prefer coffee.”

Both can mean:

> 「而 / 相比之下」

**\*\*Whereas\*\*** is usually more formal and more clearly contrastive.

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**## Important distinction: \*\*while vs although\*\***

In concessive use:

> “While I understand your concern, I disagree.”

≈

> “Although I understand your concern, I disagree.”

Both:

= 「雖然我明白你的擔心，但我不同意。」

However, **\*\*while\*\*** can also mean time or contrast, whereas **\*\*although\*\*** specifically marks concession.

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**## Important distinction: \*\*while I can vs when I can\*\***

This matters directly for your sentence.

**### \*\*while I can\*\***

= during the period in which I still have the opportunity.

> 「趁現在還可以」

This often implies that the opportunity may eventually disappear.

**### \*\*when I can\*\***

= whenever I have an opportunity.

> 「有空 / 有機會的時候」

Compare:

> “I visit her **\*\*when I can\*\***.”

= 我有機會時就去探望她。

> “I want to learn from her **while** I can.”

= 我想趁現在仍然有機會時向她學習。

Your passage deliberately uses **while** because the opportunity is limited by time.

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## Important distinction: **a while** vs **awhile**

This is essential.

### **a while**

noun phrase:

> “for a while”

> “after a while”

### **awhile**

adverb:

> “Stay awhile.”

Usually:

> **for awhile** is often considered unnecessary in careful usage because **awhile** already contains the idea of “for a while.”

For learners, the safest forms are:

> **for a while** ✓

> **stay awhile** ✓

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## Important distinction: **a while** vs **a bit**

Both can mean a short period.

### **a while**

focuses clearly on time:

> “Stay for a while.”

### \*\*a bit\*\*

is more informal and has many other meanings:

> “Stay for a bit.”

Both can mean:

> 「留一會兒。」

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## Important distinction: \*\*for a while vs in a while\*\*

### \*\*for a while\*\*

= duration

> “I waited for a while.”

= 我等了一會兒。

### \*\*in a while\*\*

= after some time from now

> “I’ll call you in a while.”

= 我過一會兒打給你。

This is a crucial learner distinction.

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## Important distinction: \*\*after a while vs in a while\*\*

### \*\*after a while\*\*

looks backward within a narrative:

> “After a while, she left.”

= 過了一陣子，她離開了。

### \*\*in a while\*\*

usually looks forward from now:

> “She’ll leave in a while.”

= 她過一會兒會離開。

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## Important distinction: \*\*while — time vs contrast\*\*

### Time:

> “She listened while he spoke.”

= 他說話時，她在聽。

### Contrast:

> “He talks a lot, while she is quiet.”

= 他說很多，而她很安靜。

Same word, different grammatical meaning.

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## Important distinction: \*\*while — contrast vs concession\*\*

### Contrast:

> “She likes cities, while I prefer the countryside.”

= 她喜歡城市，而我喜歡鄉郊。

### Concession:

> “While the plan is expensive, it may be useful.”

= 雖然計劃昂貴，但可能有用。

The first compares two things.

The second accepts one fact before introducing a qualification.

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## Important distinction: **once in a while vs sometimes**

These are very close.

### **once in a while**

= occasionally, not very often.

### **sometimes**

= on some occasions; frequency can be somewhat broader.

> “I see her once in a while.”

often implies relatively infrequent contact.

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## Important distinction: **all the while vs meanwhile**

### **all the while**

= continuously throughout the whole period.

### **meanwhile**

= during the same time, usually shifting attention to another event/person.

> “She smiled; all the while, she was worried.”

versus:

> “She cooked. Meanwhile, I made tea.”

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## Important distinction: **while vs until**

### **while**

describes what happens during a period.

### **until**

marks the endpoint of a period.

> “Stay here while I cook.”

= 我煮飯期間留在這裡。

> “Stay here until I finish cooking.”

= 留在這裡直到我煮完。

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## Important distinction: **while** vs **as long as**

They can overlap in some contexts.

### **while**

> “Stay here while I’m away.”

= 我不在期間留在這裡。

### **as long as**

can mean:

> for the whole duration that

or:

> provided that

> “You can stay as long as you’re quiet.”

= 只要你安靜，就可以留下。

So **as long as** has a conditional use that **while** does not normally have.

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## Family-extension note

**While** is a strong grammar-polysemy word because several high-frequency functions need to be kept distinct:

\* \*\*while — time\*\* = 當.....的時候 / 在.....期間  
 \* \*\*while I can\*\* = 趁仍有機會時  
 \* \*\*while — simultaneous actions\*\* = 一邊.....一邊.....  
 \* \*\*while — contrast\*\* = 而 / 相比之下  
 \* \*\*while — concession\*\* = 雖然  
 \* \*\*a while\*\* = 一段時間  
 \* \*\*for a while\*\* = 一會兒  
 \* \*\*after a while\*\* = 過了一會兒  
 \* \*\*in a while\*\* = 過一會兒  
 \* \*\*once in a while\*\* = 偶爾  
 \* \*\*all the while\*\* = 一直  
 \* \*\*quite a while\*\* = 好一段時間  
 \* \*\*worth your while\*\* = 值得花時間 / 精力  
 \* \*\*worthwhile\*\* = 值得的  
 \* \*\*awhile\*\* = 一會兒  
 \* \*\*meanwhile\*\* = 與此同時

This fits the scanning manual especially well because **while** is not primarily rich through unrelated dictionary nouns, but through **grammar-function shifts**—time, contrast, concession, and noun phrase uses—which the SOP explicitly treats as important polysemy candidates.

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## ## Master comparison

| Form / sense                        | MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| -----                               | -----                                 |
| <b>while — time</b>                 | 在某件事情持續進行的期間，另一件事情也發生                 |
| <b>while I can / while it lasts</b> | 趁某種情況仍存在或某件事仍然可以做到的期間                 |
| <b>while — simultaneous actions</b> | 表示兩件事情在同一段時間內同時發生                     |
| <b>while — background action</b>    | 以較持續的動作 / 情況作背景，另一件事在其間發生             |
| <b>while — contrast</b>             | 把兩個人、事物或情況放在一起比較；而 / 相比之下             |
| <b>while — concession</b>           | 承認某事實成立，同時引出不同或相反的觀點；雖然               |
| <b>a while</b>                      | 一段不精確、通常不太長的時間                        |
| <b>for a while</b>                  | 持續一段時間                                |
| <b>after a while</b>                | 經過一段時間之後                              |
| <b>in a while</b>                   | 從現在起過一段時間之後                           |
| <b>once in a while</b>              | 不經常；偶爾                                |
| <b>all the while</b>                | 在整段時間內一直如此                            |
| <b>a little while</b>               | 一小段時間                                 |
| <b>quite a while</b>                | 一段相當長的時間                              |
| <b>worth your while</b>             | 值得某人付出時間、精力或努力                        |
| <b>worthwhile</b>                   | 值得投入時間、努力或資源的                         |
| <b>awhile</b>                       | 一會兒；短時間地                              |
| <b>meanwhile</b>                    | 在同一段時間內；與此同時                          |

### For your original sentence

> “I want to learn from her **while I can**.”

The exact meaning is:

**while I can** = 趁我現在仍然有機會、仍然可以這樣做的時候

Therefore:

> **learn from her while I can**

= **「趁現在外婆仍然在身邊、我仍然可以和她相處的時候，多向她學習」**

The emotional nuance is important.

This is not simply:

> **when I can**

> = 有機會時

It carries a stronger awareness that:

> **the opportunity is temporary and may one day disappear**

because the previous clause says:

> “one day these visits will become memories.”

So the sequence is:

> **she is still here now → I can still learn from her → therefore I should do so while the opportunity remains**

That makes **while I can** a particularly meaningful time-limit expression in this passage.